had not been futile. The war officially came to an end when the Indian Army announced the complete eviction of Pakistani intruders on 26 July 1999. Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee declared Operation Vijay, the Indian Army's operation to push back infiltrators in the Kargil War, a success on 14 July 1999.

After the Kargil operations were over, a static display of all aircraft that had participated in the war was organized at the tarmac of the Srinagar airbase for the press and the media. No cameras were allowed and reporters were asked to use recorders only. So the reporters started interviewing pilots standing in front of their aircraft. After a while, a bunch of reporters started to gather about me as I stood in front of my Cheetah helicopter, the smallest flying machine on the tarmac that day. Soon, the crowd of reporters in front of me started to grow bigger. It was only after one of the reporters pointed this out that I realized that I was the only woman pilot on the tarmac—the only woman pilot to have flown in the combat zone during Kargil operations.

'Our fighter jets and huge transport aircraft failed to attract the media the way Gunjan's little Cheetah did today at the tarmac,' the other pilots joyfully commented later in the evening during a mess function.

It was a wonderful feeling to land back in Udhampur—there was both achievement and pride. All my unit officers had gathered on the tarmac to welcome us. I could see a broad smile on the face of my CO. The men of my unit shook hands with me as they welcomed me with a smile, the same men who had been hesitant to follow my orders or help me in preparations of my sortie back when I had just joined. It took going to a war to earn this respect. I cherished every moment of it.

What war teaches you in a few days cannot be learnt in an entire lifetime. But then again, nobody should get to learn things the way one learns during a war. Young men and women willingly sign their wills when they join the armed forces without thinking about the uncertainty of their lives, but war puts this thought before all others in their head.

Serving away from home and fighting in rough terrain is not the only price paid by soldiers defending the territorial integrity of their nation. The